essence, it has not changed since the 1913–14 Shimla conference. But the Chinese are unlikely to do anything more nowadays than issuing such official statements every time India does something noteworthy in Arunachal Pradesh, and sending occasional patrols across the border to show that they still do not recognize the McMahon Line. And India's defences along the border are stronger than ever, making such incursions little more than irritants. The stalemate in the border negotiations is, therefore, likely to continue with no solution in sight.

A much stickier point in bilateral relations is the status of Tibetan exiles in India. During Rajiv Gandhi's 1988 visit, his Chinese hosts devoted most of the time to the Tibetan issue. A communiqué was signed at the end of the visit, which said that 'The Chinese side expressed concern by anti-Chinese activities by some Tibetan elements in India. The Indian side reiterated the long-standing and consistent policy of the government of India that Tibet is an autonomous region of China and that anti-Chinese activities by Tibetan elements are not permitted on Indian soil.'[39]

Then the wording of joint Sino-Indian declarations became even stronger. According to American China specialist John W. Garver,

> By the time of Li Peng's December 1991 visit to India, the Chinese expression of "concern" in the final communiqué had expanded from fourteen words in the 1988 communiqué to forty-nine words: "The Chinese side expressed concern about the continued activities in India by some Tibetans against their motherland and reiterated that Tibet was an alienable part of Chinese territory and that it was firmly opposed to any attempt and actions aimed at splitting China and bringing about 'independence' of Tibet".[40]

By linking Tibetan activities in India to 'splitting China,' Beijing was actually intensifying pressure on New Delhi rather than defusing the situation.

Despite declarations of friendship and collaboration, the differences between China and India were obvious even on this issue. Cracking down on demonstrations and other forms of popular protest is standard practice in China, but, as Garver points out, India could agree on such restrictions of free speech only to a limited degree: 'India's core political values are, after all, liberal, holding such things as free expression and travel to be intrinsic human rights'.[41]

India can, at most, restrict, but not ban, political activities by the Tibetan exiles who want the world to know what is happening in their homeland.